

Propolis



What is it?

Propolis is a wax-like substance made by honeybees as a cement for their hives. It comes from pollens and tree resins (especially poplar and conifer buds and bark) as well as other plant species.

It is a complex mixture of 50+ agents which include resins, waxes, and plant derivatives/fragrances (i.e. cinnamyl alcohol, cinnamic acid, vanillin), and some vitamins. The main allergenic substances are 3-methyl-2-butenyl caffeate and phenylethyl caffeate.

Propolis is used in many cosmetics for its waxy and antimicrobial properties. Beeswax and propolis are related, as the wax is often mixed into the propolis by the bees; thus, non-pharmaceutical grade beeswaxes should be avoided in patients reacting to propolis.

PROPOLIS can also be known as:

- 1,1-dimethylallyl caffeic ester
- Beeswax (often contaminated with propolis)
- Bee glue
- Bee bread
- Cera alba (bleached)
- Cera flava (unbleached)
- Hive dross

Some Possible Uses of PROPOLIS / Where it might be found:

- Dental floss
- Toothpaste
- Mouthwash, canker sore care
- Lip balm, lipstick, blush
- Makeup
- Moisturizer, lotions

- Ointments
- Shaving cream, aftershave
- Sunscreen
- Anti-aging mask, toner, serum
- Hair products
- Facial cleanser, scrub
- Body wash, shower gel
- Depilatory wax
- Cuticle care
- First aid ointment
- Scar treatment, Royal Jelly
- Cough syrups, lozenges
- Vitamins and other pills
- Chewing gum, chewing chunks
- Beeswax candles
- Natural honey
- Health food store products
- Traditional medicines
- "Natural" or "folk" remedies
- Local anesthetic
- Hobby wood
- Leather or wood varnish
- Violin, cello, guitar varnish/wax
- Beehives

Other products that may cross-react to PROPOLIS:

Since propolis comes from tree resins, patients may show cross sensitivity to fragrances, such as:

- Balsam of Peru
- Benzyl salicylate
- Cinnamates (cinnamic aldehyde, cinnamic acid, cinnamyl alcohol)
- Vanillin
- Benzoates
- Coumaric acid
- Ferulic acids

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Some who are allergic to propolis should avoid all fragrance containing products as there may be cross reactivity between propolis and fragrances. **If you use the CAMP app, your provider will designate whether you need to avoid propolis and fragrance or just propolis.**

What should I do to avoid PROPOLIS?

To avoid propolis, check the complete ingredient list of each product you use for any of the names above. For products already at home that do not list ingredients, go to the store and inspect the original box or package. Some products' ingredient lists are available on the internet at the manufacturer's or store's website.

Your exposure to propolis may be from contact with a partner who uses products that contain it. Ask your aesthetician, masseuse, and others to avoid using items with propolis in your care.

Pharmaceutical grade beeswax does not contain propolis.

To find a possible workplace exposure, check the complete ingredient list of each product you encounter there. It may be necessary to contact the manufacturer. Wear rubber or vinyl gloves if you must handle products that contain propolis in your work.

Allergic beekeepers will have to avoid contact with bee hives or use thick rubber, leather, or vinyl gloves for all such contact.

In addition, the ACDS Contact Allergen Management Program® (CAMP®) can help manage contact dermatitis. It helps to find products that are safe to use by creating a list of products that do not contain one's allergens. For more information about CAMP®, please ask your doctor or visit www.contactderm.org.

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